THE OPEN SOURCE AUDIT

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THE OPEN SOURCE AUDIT

A Capstone Project Report Course: Open Source Software | Units 1–5 | Max Marks: 100 **Software Analyzed:** Firefox — Open Source Web Browser | Licence: Mozilla Public Licence 2.0

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  - **Slot:** A13
  - **Date of Submission:** 31-03-2026

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1. Introduction

This document provides a comprehensive audit of Mozilla Firefox, one of the most prominent open-source web browsers globally. In stark contrast to proprietary alternatives engineered by tech conglomerates like Microsoft, Apple, or Google, Firefox is uniquely designed to prioritize end-users rather than corporate shareholders or advertisers. Operating as a non-profit entity, the Mozilla Foundation (alongside its subsidiary, the Mozilla Corporation) champions the mission of preserving a secure, universal, and open internet.

Historically, Firefox holds a critical place in the open-source movement. It was forged from the remnants of Netscape Navigator, a previously dominant browser that was decimated by Microsoft's anticompetitive market strategies in the late 1990s. Studying Firefox provides essential insights into the historical battle for internet freedom and the strategic implementation of open-source frameworks as a defense mechanism. This report evaluates the browser across four main sections corresponding to units 1-5 of the Open Source Software curriculum. Additionally, five Ubuntu-compatible shell scripts are provided in the accompanying GitHub repository.

Part A — Origin and Philosophy (Units 1 & 2)

A1. The Problem Firefox Was Created to Solve To fully grasp the significance of Firefox, one must examine the 1995 "browser wars". The initial pioneer of the commercial web was Netscape Navigator, a product of Netscape Communications Corporation. It introduced foundational web technologies still used today, such as SSL encryption, cookies, and JavaScript. During its peak, Netscape controlled roughly 80% of the browser market, effectively dictating the architecture of the early web.

Recognizing that control over the browser meant control over internet standards, Microsoft perceived Netscape as a direct threat to its operating system dominance. Microsoft retaliated by aggressively bundling its own browser, Internet Explorer, at no cost with the Windows OS. This maneuver—later condemned as anticompetitive by US federal courts—proved disastrous for Netscape. By the year 2001, Netscape was collapsing while Internet Explorer secured over 90% of the market.

Facing imminent obsolescence in 1998, Netscape made the unprecedented decision to release its source code freely to the public. This initiative birthed the "Mozilla" project—a name blending "Mosaic killer" (referencing the original Mosaic browser) with "Godzilla"—designed to maintain and improve the Netscape Communicator codebase. Mozilla's overarching goal was to engineer an unkillable, community-owned browser.

Because the original Mozilla Suite suffered from performance bloat, developers Blake Ross and Dave Hyatt pivoted in 2002 to create a streamlined, agile browser. Originally called Phoenix, and later Firebird, this project officially launched as Firefox 1.0 on November 9, 2004. Supported by a crowdfunded advertisement in the New York Times, it achieved over 100 million downloads in its first year, marking an unprecedented software launch. The Mozilla Foundation was formally incorporated in 2003 to protect the project's intellectual property after AOL acquired and subsequently dismantled Netscape. Today, Mozilla continues its core mission: defending a decentralized internet free from monopolistic control.

A2. The Licence — What MPL 2.0 Actually Says Firefox operates under the Mozilla Public Licence version 2.0 (MPL 2.0). This licensing framework offers a strategic compromise between highly permissive licenses (e.g., BSD or MIT) and stringent copyleft licenses (e.g., GPL v2). It guarantees the GNU Project's four foundational software freedoms: the right to execute the software, study and alter the code, distribute copies, and share modifications. Consequently, anyone can access the Firefox repository via GitHub or hg.mozilla.org, review the codebase, and modify it without restriction.

The defining characteristic of MPL 2.0 is its application of "file-level" copyleft. Unlike GPL v2, which mandates that an entire project adopting modified code must become open source, MPL 2.0 only requires that modifications to *existing* MPL-licensed files remain open. Developers are free to introduce entirely new proprietary files alongside

the MPL files. This file-level flexibility makes MPL 2.0 highly attractive for commercial enterprises.

- **Copyleft scope:** MPL 2.0 applies at the file-level, while GPL v2 applies at the project-level.
- **Proprietary integration:** MPL 2.0 allows combination with proprietary code, whereas GPL v2 forbids it.
- **Commercial application:** MPL 2.0 allows commercialization without forcing new files to be shared; GPL v2 mandates source sharing for modified distributions.
- **Patent protections:** MPL 2.0 includes strong, explicit contributor patent grants; GPL v2 relies on implied protections.
- **Notable Adopters:** MPL 2.0 is utilized by Firefox and LibreOffice, whereas GPL v2 is used by the Linux kernel and Git.

This structure permits corporations to build proprietary browsers using Firefox's core rendering engine (Gecko) as long as they license core engine modifications under MPL 2.0. Examples of browsers leveraging this include Basilisk, Pale Moon, and Waterfox. This license demonstrates the difference between software that is merely cost-free (like Internet Explorer, whose closed source prevented independent auditing) and software that offers true operational freedom (like Firefox). MPL 2.0 is optimal for robust, user-facing applications requiring commercial flexibility, whereas MIT is better for maximizing library adoption, and GPL v2 is best for strictly open infrastructure.

A3. The Ethics of Open Source Web browsers are not standard applications; they act as the primary conduits through which billions of users manage their finances, health data, and communications. They inherently possess intimate knowledge of user behaviors and preferences. When controlled by corporations reliant on advertising revenue, this data becomes a lucrative and potentially exploitative asset. Google Chrome exemplifies this ethical conflict: its users are at odds with the advertising interests of its parent company.

Open-source browsers are an ethical imperative because they allow independent researchers to verify how user data is handled. Firefox serves as living proof that human information gateways do not require corporate oversight. Conversely, profit-driven models often yield superior technical optimization; Google's massive engineering resources allowed Chrome to rapidly outpace Firefox in speed between 2008 and 2015. This highlights a real ethical dilemma between choosing a technically inferior private browser versus a highly optimized proprietary browser with embedded tracking.

The financial dynamic of Mozilla is also complex. The non-profit predominantly funds its operations through a lucrative contract with Google, making Google the default search

engine in Firefox. While this money funds vital internet health initiatives, it underscores the nuanced relationship between open-source ideals and commercial realities. Nevertheless, open source remains a massive driver of browser innovation. Apple utilized the KDE community's KHTML engine to create WebKit, which Google later adapted into Blink. Similarly, Mozilla’s open Gecko engine has been crucial in establishing universal web standards like CSS, JavaScript, and privacy protocols, preventing a fractured, proprietary internet.

Part B — Linux Footprint on Ubuntu (Unit 2)

Installation and Key Directories Firefox is natively supported on Ubuntu via the APT repository as an Extended Support Release (ESR). It can be installed and verified using the following commands: sudo apt update && sudo apt install firefox-esr -y firefox-esr --version

For users requiring immediate feature updates outside the APT cycle, tarball releases are available directly from mozilla.org.

- **/usr/bin/firefox-esr**: Acts as the primary symbolic link to the binary executable.
- **/usr/lib/firefox-esr/**: Houses core application libraries and structural assets.
- **/usr/share/applications/**: Contains the GUI integration file (firefox-esr.desktop).
- **/usr/share/doc/firefox-esr/**: Stores copyright details and changelogs.
- **~/.mozilla/firefox/**: The isolated user directory storing private data (passwords, history).
- **/etc/firefox/**: Contains system-wide enterprise policies.

User, Group, and Security Architecture Firefox operates under the currently logged-in desktop user rather than requiring a dedicated system account. To prevent tampering, the core binary files stored in /usr/lib/firefox-esr/ are owned by the root user. Conversely, sensitive user data—such as encrypted passwords and browsing history—are isolated within the user's ~/.mozilla/firefox/ directory. This architectural separation ensures that if a malicious script compromises the browser, the attacker only gains access to the local user profile rather than system-wide root access. Because of this vulnerability vector, modern Ubuntu systems strongly advise against operating a desktop environment as the root user.

Service Management and Update Model Firefox functions strictly as a user-launched desktop application, lacking a systemd unit file. Processes are managed manually via commands like firefox-esr & for launching, pkill firefox-esr for termination, and pgrep -la

firefox for process monitoring. For server or testing environments, Firefox offers a headless mode capable of generating PDFs or capturing screenshots without a graphical interface.

Security updates for Ubuntu users are deployed through the APT package manager, while non-APT users rely on Mozilla's built-in updater. Thanks to its transparent development processes on GitHub and Phabricator, Mozilla can crowdsource security reviews globally, often patching critical zero-day vulnerabilities (like the CVE-2023-4863 WebP buffer overflow) within a 48-hour window.

Part C — The FOSS Ecosystem (Units 3 & 4)

Dependencies and Technological Contributions Firefox relies heavily on a network of FOSS components:

- **Gecko & SpiderMonkey:** Mozilla's proprietary MPL-licensed engines for rendering web pages and executing JavaScript.
- **NSS / NSPR:** Handles critical cryptographic and TLS/SSL operations.
- **SQLite:** Public domain software used to log local bookmarks and history.
- **Rust:** An MIT/Apache 2.0 language engineered by Mozilla for memory-safe development.

Beyond its browser, Mozilla has drastically shaped the digital ecosystem. It spearheaded standardizations for universally adopted protocols like WebRTC, CSS animations, WebGL, and IndexedDB. Furthermore, Mozilla's creation of the Rust programming language—initially designed to secure Firefox components—has revolutionized the industry, with widespread adoption by Amazon, Microsoft, and the Linux kernel project. Mozilla also founded MDN Web Docs, which remains the definitive, free documentation standard for developers globally.

In the context of the LAMP stack, Firefox acts as the primary client interface. Its built-in, fully open-source DevTools are essential for developers needing to debug code, inspect network requests, and simulate mobile environments. System administrators heavily rely on Firefox's verifiable security enforcement and "same origin" policies to safely interface with backend control panels like phpMyAdmin. Governed by the US-based Mozilla Foundation, the browser is sustained by a vast network of paid engineers, volunteer contributors, and annual gatherings like MozFest.

Part D — Open Source vs Proprietary (Critical Analysis)

Comparative Overview: Firefox vs. Google Chrome

- **Cost & Privacy:** While both browsers are free to download, Chrome's hidden cost involves extensive data harvesting to support Google's advertising infrastructure. Firefox lacks this advertising revenue model and implements Enhanced Tracking Protection by default.
- **Security & Modification:** Firefox operates under MPL 2.0, permitting total codebase auditing and modification. Chrome is built on open-source Chromium but incorporates locked, proprietary APIs and DRM that prevent full external audits.
- **Governance:** Chrome development follows Google's commercial mandates, whereas Firefox is community-driven and governed by a nonprofit mission.

Conclusion For individuals, governmental agencies, and journalists requiring absolute privacy and verifiable security, Firefox remains the premier choice. Because it operates independently of advertising agendas, its security architecture can be mathematically and publicly verified rather than blindly trusted.

Technically speaking, Google Chrome still holds performance advantages, particularly regarding the execution speeds of its V8 JavaScript engine and widespread web application compatibility. However, Mozilla consistently reduces this performance gap with each update, maintaining undisputed superiority in privacy metrics. Firefox is an essential tool that warrants both usage and developer contribution, offering accessible pathways for volunteers to assist with localization, accessibility, and DevTools enhancement.

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5. Shell Script Documentation

The following five shell scripts were engineered and verified on Ubuntu.

Script 1: System Identity Report

Function: Generates a comprehensive system dashboard detailing OS version, kernel, uptime, user profile, and Firefox installation status. *Core Concepts:* Command substitution, variables, and formatted output pipelines.

Bash

```
#!/bin/bash

# Script 1: System Identity Report [cite: 532]

# Description: Generates an overview of current system and user metrics [cite: 534]
```

```
USER_IDENT="Siddharth "
APP_TARGET="Firefox"

# Execute system commands via substitution [cite: 537]
SYS_KERNEL=$(uname -r)
SYS_OS=$(cat /etc/os-release | grep PRETTY_NAME | cut -d= -f2 | tr -d '"')
ACTIVE_USER=$(whoami)
USER_HOME=$HOME
SYS_UPTIME=$(uptime -p)
TIMESTAMP=$(date '+%d %B %Y, %H:%M')
APP_VER=$(firefox-esr --version 2>/dev/null || echo 'Not installed')

# Print formatted dashboard [cite: 545]
echo "==================================================="
echo "   OPEN SOURCE AUDIT — SYSTEM IDENTITY DASHBOARD  "
echo "==================================================="
echo "Auditor     : $USER_IDENT"
echo "Target App  : $APP_TARGET"
echo "---------------------------------------------------"
echo "Kernel Info : $SYS_KERNEL"
echo "OS Release  : $SYS_OS"
echo "Logged User : $ACTIVE_USER"
echo "Home Path   : $USER_HOME"
echo "Run Time    : $SYS_UPTIME"
echo "Timestamp   : $TIMESTAMP"
echo "App Version : $APP_VER"
```

```
echo "Base License: GNU General Public License v2 (GPL v2) — Ubuntu"
echo "==================================================="
```

Script 2: FOSS Package Inspector

Function: Validates the installation state of the Firefox ESR package and utilizes conditional logic to output philosophical context. *Core Concepts:* dpkg, grep, if-then-else, case statements.

Bash

```
#!/bin/bash
# Script 2: FOSS Package Inspector [cite: 565]
# Description: Validates package status and outputs related FOSS philosophy [cite: 567]

TARGET_PKG="firefox-esr"

# Verify package existence using dpkg [cite: 569]
if dpkg -l $TARGET_PKG &>/dev/null; then
    echo "Status    : $TARGET_PKG is currently INSTALLED."
    echo "-----------------------------------------------------------"
    dpkg -l $TARGET_PKG | grep '^ii' | awk '{print "Version   : " $3}'
    apt-cache show $TARGET_PKG | grep -E '^(Homepage|Maintainer)' | head -2
else
    echo "$TARGET_PKG is missing from this system."
    echo "Execute: sudo apt install firefox-esr to install."
fi

echo ""
echo "--- Contextual FOSS Note ---"

# Output philosophy based on package string [cite: 581]
```

```
case $TARGET_PKG in
    firefox-esr|firefox)
        echo "Firefox: Engineered to prevent the monopolization of the web."
        echo "A legacy of Netscape, sustained by a community valuing digital freedom." ;;
    git)
        echo "Git: A decentralized necessity born from proprietary constraints." ;;
    python3)
        echo "Python: Driven by community consensus rather than corporate mandate." ;;
    apache2)
        echo "Apache: The foundational server architecture of the free web." ;;
    *)
        echo "Open source software. Review the codebase for transparency." ;;
esac
```

Script 3: Disk and Permission Auditor

Function: Iterates across critical directories to analyze disk usage and permission structures, alongside a targeted check of the Firefox profile. *Core Concepts:* Arrays, loops, awk, cut, du.

Bash

```
#!/bin/bash
# Script 3: Disk and Permission Auditor [cite: 601]
# Description: Evaluates access rights and sizes for core filesystem paths [cite: 603]

TARGET_DIRS=("/etc" "/var/log" "/home" "/usr/bin" "/tmp")

echo "Filesystem Audit Report"
echo "---------------------------------------------"
printf "%-18s %-8s %-22s\n" "Path" "Storage" "Rights / Owner / Group"
echo "---------------------------------------------"
```

```
# Iterate over directory array [cite: 609]
for PATH_DIR in "${TARGET_DIRS[@]}"; do
    if [ -d "$PATH_DIR" ]; then
        ACCESS_RIGHTS=$(ls -ld "$PATH_DIR" | awk '{print $1, $3, $4}')
        STORAGE_USE=$(du -sh "$PATH_DIR" 2>/dev/null | cut -f1)
        printf "%-18s %-8s %-22s\n" "$PATH_DIR" "${STORAGE_USE:-N/A}"
"$ACCESS_RIGHTS"
    else
        echo "Path $PATH_DIR is invalid."
    fi
done

# Analyze user-specific Firefox directory [cite: 619]
echo ""
echo "--- Profile Directory Analysis ---"
USER_FF_PROFILE="$HOME/.mozilla/firefox"

if [ -d "$USER_FF_PROFILE" ]; then
    echo "Profile Located: $USER_FF_PROFILE"
    ACCESS_RIGHTS=$(ls -ld "$USER_FF_PROFILE" | awk '{print $1, $3, $4}')
    STORAGE_USE=$(du -sh "$USER_FF_PROFILE" 2>/dev/null | cut -f1)
    echo "Access Rights : $ACCESS_RIGHTS"
    echo "Storage Used  : ${STORAGE_USE:-N/A}"
else
    echo "Profile missing. Execute Firefox to generate initial directories."
fi
```

Script 4: Log File Analyzer

Function: Scans a designated log file for a specific string (defaulting to 'error') and isolates the most recent occurrences. *Core Concepts:* Command-line arguments, while loops, iterators, tail.

Bash

```
#!/bin/bash

# Script 4: Log File Analyzer [cite: 636]

# Usage format: ./log_analyzer.sh <path_to_log> [search_term] [cite: 637]


TARGET_LOG=$1

SEARCH_TERM=${2:-"error"}

MATCH_COUNT=0


# Ensure log argument exists [cite: 642]

if [ -z "$TARGET_LOG" ]; then

    echo "Syntax: $0 <log_path> [search_term]"; exit 1

fi


# Verify file validity [cite: 646]

if [ ! -f "$TARGET_LOG" ]; then

    echo "Fatal: $TARGET_LOG cannot be found."; exit 1

fi


# Ensure file contains data [cite: 650]

if [ ! -s "$TARGET_LOG" ]; then

    echo "Notice: $TARGET_LOG contains no data."; exit 0

fi
```

```
echo "Scanning Path : $TARGET_LOG"
echo "Search Term   : $SEARCH_TERM"
echo "---------------------------------------------"

# Process log data line iteratively [cite: 657]
while IFS= read -r TEXT_LINE; do
    if echo "$TEXT_LINE" | grep -iq "$SEARCH_TERM"; then
        MATCH_COUNT=$((MATCH_COUNT + 1))
    fi
done < "$TARGET_LOG"

echo "Term '$SEARCH_TERM' detected $MATCH_COUNT instance(s)."
echo ""

# Output final 5 entries if matches exist [cite: 666]
if [ $MATCH_COUNT -gt 0 ]; then
    echo "Recent Log Entries:"
    grep -i "$SEARCH_TERM" "$TARGET_LOG" | tail -5
fi
```

Script 5: Open Source Manifesto Generator

Function: Prompts the user for text input and concatenates the responses into a persistently saved manifesto file. *Core Concepts:* Redirection (> and >>), read, timestamps.

Bash

```
#!/bin/bash
# Script 5: Open Source Manifesto Generator [cite: 675]

echo "===================================="
```

```
echo "    FOSS MANIFESTO CONFIGURATOR     "
echo "======================================"

# Collect data via read prompts [cite: 682]
read -p "1. Identify a daily open-source tool: " FOSS_TOOL
read -p "2. Define digital freedom in one word: " FREE_DEF
read -p "3. A project you aspire to build openly: " DEV_GOAL

CURRENT_TS=$(date '+%d %B %Y')
OUT_FILE="manifesto_$(whoami).txt"

# Generate output text file [cite: 688]
echo "FOSS Manifesto — $CURRENT_TS" > "$OUT_FILE"
echo "--------------------------------------------" >> "$OUT_FILE"
echo "" >> "$OUT_FILE"
echo "I consistently utilize $FOSS_TOOL, a testament to transparent development." >> "$OUT_FILE"
echo "Digital freedom equates to $FREE_DEF, a core pillar of the FOSS community." >> "$OUT_FILE"
echo "This ecosystem thrives on collaborative improvement." >> "$OUT_FILE"
echo "Firefox exists because developers rejected corporate web monopolies." >> "$OUT_FILE"
echo "My objective is to engineer $DEV_GOAL and distribute it freely," >> "$OUT_FILE"
echo "allowing future engineers to build upon my foundational work." >> "$OUT_FILE"
echo "This is the commitment of the open-source community." >> "$OUT_FILE"

echo ""
echo "Data exported to: $OUT_FILE"
```

```
cat "$OUT_FILE"
```

6. Conclusion

Evaluating Firefox represents an exploration of software development as a form of digital resistance. The browser did not originate from a desire to generate profit, but rather as an emergency response to a critical era where a single corporation threatened to monopolize web access. Its governing MPL 2.0 license brilliantly balances the necessity of preventing proprietary hijackers with the flexibility required to build viable commercial products.

Ultimately, web browsers are not passive utilities; they dictate how modern society engages with news, education, and global communication. The motivations of the entities building these portals are profoundly impactful. Firefox proves that a dedicated community and non-profit organization can rival trillion-dollar tech giants, pioneer new programming paradigms, and actively defend human rights online. Recognizing this dynamic is fundamental to grasping the true purpose of open-source software.

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